



THE MORNING KICKOFF

📅 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Quarter-finals — one tie a day through Sunday

📅 The quarter-finals begin tonight in Boston

👤 Mbappé can level Messi's 8 goals tonight

📅 One tie a day: Spain–Belgium Fri, Norway–England Sat, Argentina–Switzerland Sun

⚡ QUARTER-FINAL WEEK

THE REMATCH FRANCE NEVER WANTED

Qatar 2022, semi-final: France 2, Morocco 0 — and a football continent left wondering what might have been. Tonight in Boston they meet again, one round earlier, with France unbeaten and scoring freely, and a Morocco side that has conceded just once in the knockouts. The last eight starts with its heavyweight bout.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ The Crystal Ball is back tonight: the live market has France at 62%, but a quarter of the money sits on the draw.
- ⚡ Morocco lose forward Ismael Saibari to injury — a real blow to their counter-attack.
- 📅 Tomorrow: Spain–Belgium in Los Angeles (18:00) — the market already makes Spain 60% favourites.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 Tonight: France–Morocco, the 2022 semi-final rematch — full preview and key men
- P.3 The Crystal Ball: our call with \$1.7m of live market money behind the numbers
- P.4 Golden Boot: Messi leads on 8 — Mbappé hunts him tonight, Haaland and Kane on Saturday
- P.5 The bracket, the semi-final routes, and your week to the final



Kylian Mbappé — seven goals, two assists, and a Golden Boot one strike away

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)



France – Morocco



22:00

FULL PREVIEWS PAGE 2 →



THE MORNING
KICKOFF

Thursday 9 July 2026 · Edition #4 · Schedule, team news & stats: FIFA, ESPN, Goal, Olympics.com, Yahoo Sports, DraftKings Network — checked morning of 9 July 2026. Live market prices: Kalshi (\$1.7m traded on tonight's tie). Kick-off times in Central European Time unless flagged otherwise.

QF1 · THE 2022 SEMI-FINAL, REPLAYED



France

VS

Morocco






22:00



23:00



01:30 +1



16:00



14:00

Kick-off 4:00 PM ET at the stadium

📍 Gillette Stadium, Boston

France have been the tournament's most complete attacking side: five wins from five, none needing extra time, 14 goals, and the Mbappé–Dembélé axis purring. Morocco have built their run the other way — a defensive wall that dismantled Canada 3–0 and has conceded once in the knockouts. In Qatar they made history reaching the semi-final; France ended it, 2–0. Tonight is the chance to rewrite that ending, without the injured Ismael Saibari.

- 👁 Mbappé (7 goals) can level Messi's Golden Boot lead — or pass it
- 👁 Hakimi against his boyhood city club teammate Dembélé down France's left
- 👁 The winner meets Spain or Belgium in Tuesday's Dallas semi-final



KEY MAN · MOROCCO

Achraf Hakimi

Captain of the wall. Born in Madrid, made in Paris, and the man who must somehow patrol the wing where Mbappé — his old PSG teammate — does his worst.

HOW THE LAST EIGHT WAS SETTLED

This week's round-of-16 results

 Portugal 0 – 1  Spain 0–1

 United States 1 – 4  Belgium 1–4

 Argentina 3 – 2  Egypt 3–2

 Switzerland 0 – 0  Colombia pens

TOMORROW: QF2 — SPAIN-BELGIUM IN LOS ANGELES  Spain –  Belgium 18:00

France v Morocco

★ OUR CALL: FRANCE 2-1

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO REACH THE SEMI-FINAL



⚡ LIVE MARKET · KALSHI PREDICTION MARKET · REGULATION-TIME WINNER · \$1.7M TRADED

France 62% Tie 25% Morocco 15%

FORM

France: five wins from five, 14 scored, never needed extra time.
Morocco: one goal conceded in the knockouts and a 3-0 dismantling of Canada.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

The 2022 semi-final is the reference point: France won 2-0 in Qatar on the night Morocco's historic run ended. Most of both cores were there.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

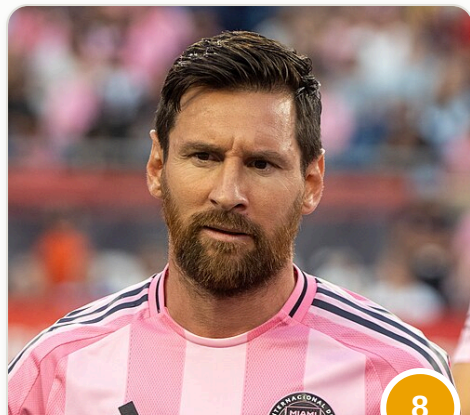
Morocco are without forward Ismael Saibari, a genuine loss to their transition game. France report a clean bill and have played the fewest hard minutes of any quarter-finalist.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Kalshi's live market (\$1.7m traded): France 62%, the draw 25%, Morocco 15% in regulation. A full quarter of the money expects this level after 90 minutes.

⚡ THE VERDICT Morocco will make it ugly, and the draw price says the market respects that. But France's front line is the one force in this tournament no block has contained, and Saibari's absence blunts the counter Morocco would need. France — later than their fans would like.

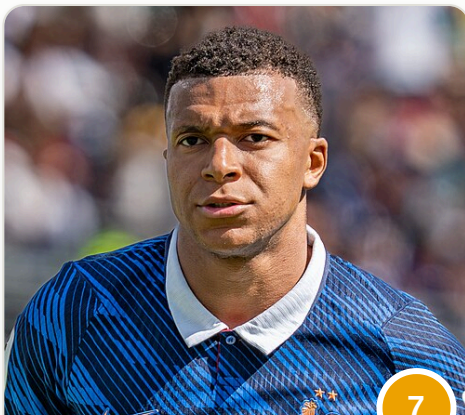
The Crystal Ball is for family bragging rights only. Probabilities blend live prediction-market prices with our own reading of form, fitness and history. Entertainment — not financial or betting advice. Record so far: 2 winners called from 4.



8

Lionel Messi

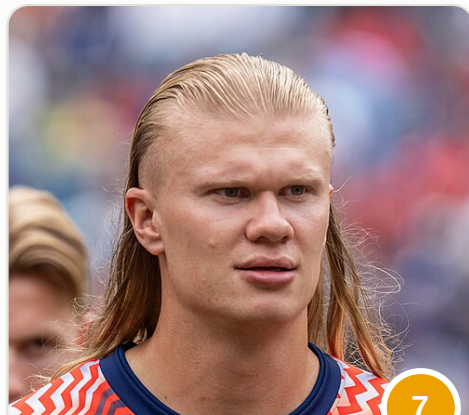
Watches tonight; plays Switzerland in Sunday's quarter-final



7

Kylian Mbappé

Plays tonight — one goal levels Messi, and his assists win the tie-break



7

Erling Haaland

Saturday night against England's defence in Miami



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Mbappé's 2 assists mean 8 goals tonight would take the outright lead.

⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

2–0

The 2022 semi-final — the only previous World Cup meeting, France's night in Qatar

14

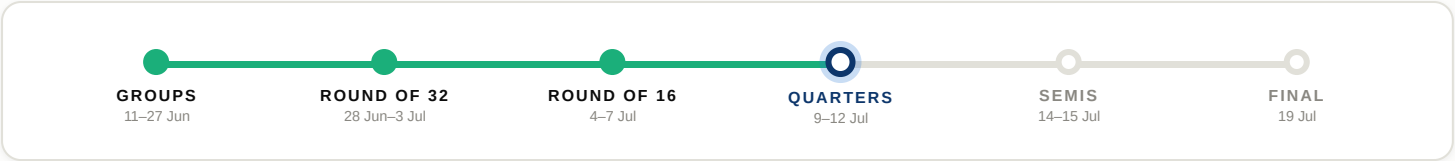
France's goals in five games — the tournament's most dangerous attack

1

Goal conceded by Morocco in the knockout rounds

5/5

France are the only team to win every game without needing extra time



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · Thu 9 July · 22:00 · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · Fri 10 July · 18:00 · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · Sat 11 July · 23:00 · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · Sun 12 July · 02:00 (+1) · Kansas City

Argentina

Switzerland

SEMI-FINALS

Tue 14 July · Dallas

Tonight's winner vs Spain/Belgium

Wed 15 July · Atlanta

Norway/England vs Argentina/Switzerland

THE FINAL

Sunday 19 July

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Monday 6 — Sunday 12 July

THU
9 Jul

QF1 France–Morocco · 22:00

FRI
10 Jul

QF2 Spain–Belgium · 18:00

SAT
11 Jul

QF3 Norway–England · 23:00

SUN
12 Jul

QF4 Argentina–Switzerland · 02:00 (+1)

MON
13 Jul

Rest day

TUE
14 Jul

Semi-final 1 in Dallas

WED
15 Jul

Semi-final 2 in Atlanta

See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the France–Morocco report with the full timeline and stats, plus the Crystal Ball's call on Spain–Belgium.

Player photos: Bryan Berlin (CC BY-SA 4.0), via Wikimedia Commons.